



ups and downs, the 29-year-old registered a healthy rate of 123.17, with 186 runs in eight games this year. She struck at over 127 during the Women's Premier League campaign with the Gujarat Giants this year, giving chief selector Neetu David, head coach Amol Muzumdar (**above, centre**) and Harmanpreet (**above, right**) the confidence to back her in place of the injured Yastika Bhatia. Both players have been named in the squad, with a close eye on Yastika's fitness.

Openers Shafali Verma and Smriti Mandhana (**above, left**) have enjoyed all-format success both individually and as a pair, while Jemimah Rodrigues has come a long way from the batting slump that

affected her confidence a few seasons ago. **Richa Ghosh's explosive finishing abilities have greatly eased India's anxieties about closing out games.**

India is carrying a spin-heavy bowling arsenal to the UAE. In Deepti Sharma, Radha Yadav, Sajana Sajeevan, Asha Sobhana Joy, Tanuja Kanwer (reserve), and Shreyanka Patil, the team has versatility and effectiveness in its ranks. A nagging injury to Shreyanka's left hand has been a worry, due to which India has been frugal while using her in matches. The Bengaluru-based allrounder and Yastika — a crucial left-hander in India's batting plans — will push the coaching staff to err on the side of caution.

Unfamiliar territory: India's run-up to the biennial event has been unusually cold. K. MURALI KUMAR

« Australia, now led by Alyssa Healy (right), has won the tournament a record six times in eight editions »



EMMANUEL YOGINI